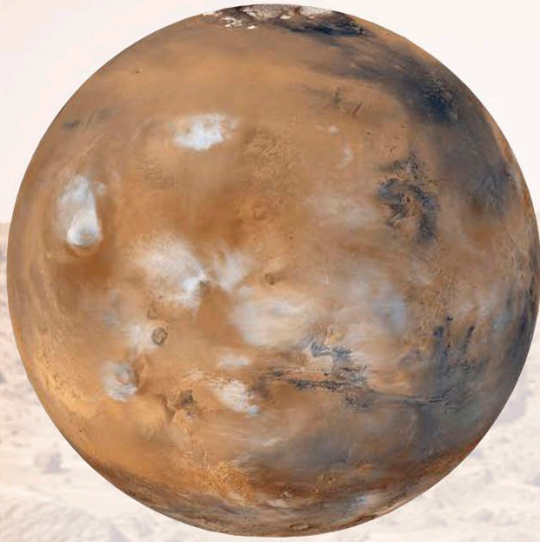


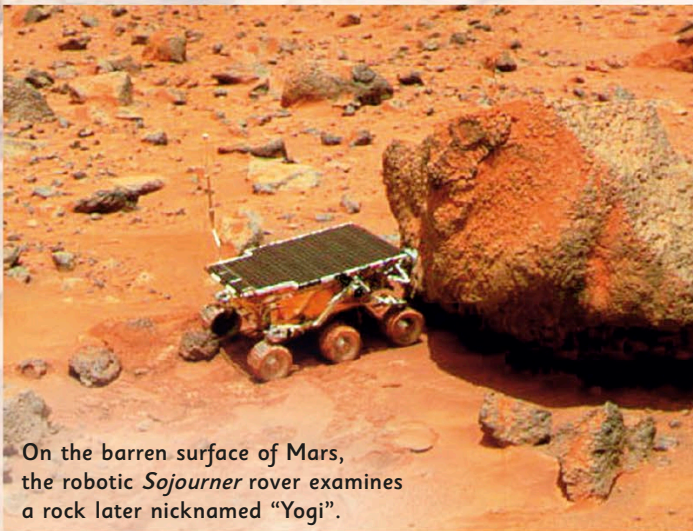
Exploring Mars



Spacecraft have flown past Mars, orbited it, and landed on its surface. One day, we may even build a base on Mars. It may be cold, barren, and dusty, but it's full of possibilities.

Why study Mars?

At some point in its history, Mars, also called the Red Planet, may have supported life forms. Although it is about half the size of the Earth, it has clouds, weather patterns, and polar icecaps – once it even had active volcanoes. Learning about Mars may help us to understand our own planet.



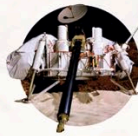
On the barren surface of Mars, the robotic *Sojourner* rover examines a rock later nicknamed "Yogi".

Seeing red

The landing craft that visited Mars took lots of pictures of its surface. These show a layer of soil that is rich in iron, which gives Mars its red colour – like rusty iron on the Earth.

Looking at Mars

There have been a number of missions to Mars.



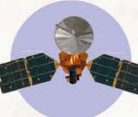
The **Viking landers** were two spacecraft that tested for signs of life in 1976.



Pathfinder touched down in 1997 and released a small rover called *Sojourner*.



Mars Express is Europe's first mission to a planet. It has been taking photos from orbit since 2004.



Mars Reconnaissance Orbiter began orbiting in 2006. It maps and takes detailed images of Mars.



The car-sized **Curiosity** rover is the latest one to work on Mars. It landed in 2012.

